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What Is AI? Unplugged First Lesson

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AGES 4-8 · NO SCREENS · ABOUT 20 MINUTES

What is AI? An unplugged first lesson

Your child hears "AI" everywhere. This is a first lesson you can run at the kitchen table with zero screens — three short games that build a true, age-honest picture: AI is a computer program that learns from examples and makes guesses, it's often wrong, and people are the ones in charge. A read-aloud script is included; say it in your own words.

BEFORE YOU START, FOR THE GROWN-UP

Kids under 13 don't use AI chatbots themselves — that's the tools' own rule.
You hold the keyboard. Today needs no keyboard at all.

Game 1 · The sorting machine ages 4-8

Pour out blocks, buttons, or silverware. Ask your child to sort them — by color, then by size, then let them invent a rule while you guess it.

*"You just did what AI does! A computer can learn to sort things too — but it has to see **lots and lots** of examples first. You needed only a few, because you're a person, and people are very good at this."*

Game 2 · The pattern guesser ages 4-8

Line up a pattern: spoon, fork, spoon, fork... and ask what comes next. Make it trickier until they miss one — then celebrate the miss.

*"AI works like this: it guesses what comes next from patterns it has seen. And just like your guess, **AI's guess can be wrong**. That's why we always check — a guess is not the same as knowing."*

Game 3 · The robot parent ages 5-8

You are a robot who does exactly what it's told. Ask your child to give you instructions for making a sandwich or brushing teeth — and follow them ridiculously literally ("put butter on the bread" → the whole stick, wrapper on).

*"Computers do exactly what the instructions say — not what we **meant**. People who use AI have to say things clearly, check what comes back, and fix it. The computer follows; the person is in charge."*

The three things worth remembering

- **AI learns from examples** — like the sorting game, but with millions of examples.
- **AI guesses; it doesn't know.** Guesses can be wrong, so people check.
- **People are in charge.** AI is a tool, like a very fast pencil — and grown-ups hold it for now.

When they ask "can I talk to it?" — an honest answer that holds up: "The chatbot tools are built for people 13 and up, like the deep end of the pool. For now, I use them and you can watch me sometimes — and everything we did today is exactly how they work on the inside."

Grown-up, your turn next: our Homeschool AI Planning Pack turns AI into your planning assistant — unit studies, leveled readings, and weekly rhythms drafted in minutes, decided by you. In our TpT store, with more free resources like this one.

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